PRACTICAL LAWS OF PESAH

Kashering Utensils

Practical Laws of Pesah

With Rabbi Daniel Kada

Foundations: Torah Sources for Kashering

Source 1 — Vayikra 6:21 (Parashat Tzav): The Korban Chatat

The Torah discusses the sin offering which had to be consumed by dawn the next morning. It states:

- An **earthenware utensil** in which the sacrifice was cooked must be **broken** — it cannot be kashered.
- A **copper (metal) utensil** need only be **purged and rinsed with water**.

Two principles derived:

1. Earthenware vessels can never be kashered. The Torah testifies: "he'idah Torah al klei cheres she-einam yotz'im mi-yedei dofyan le-olam" — they can never be rectified.
2. Metal vessels can be kashered through purging with water.

Source 2 — Bamidbar 31 (Parashat Matot): The Midianite Booty

After the war with Midian, Elazar ben Aharon instructed the people on how to kasher captured utensils:

- Whatever was used with fire → pass through fire
- Whatever was used with hot water → purge in hot water
- Whatever was used cold → just wash

Rashi's famous formulation: "Ke-vol'o kach polto" — the way it absorbs is the way it must be expelled.

Is Kashering a Mitzvah?

Opinion	Ruling
Tosafot	Yes — a mitzvah, comparable to tevilat kelim
Rambam and majority of Rishonim	No — it is not one of the 613 mitzvot. It is merely a preparation, removing something that prevents you from using the utensil.

Practical consequence: No bracha is recited on kashering utensils. This is comparable to salting meat to remove blood or removing forbidden fats — necessary processes, but not intrinsic mitzvot.

Contrast with tevilat kelim: Immersing a utensil bought from a non-Jew is a positive transformation (from non-Jewish domain to Jewish domain) — that is why it has a bracha and is one of the 613 mitzvot.

The Two Methods of Kashering

1. Libun (Burning / Red Hot)

Definition: Heating the utensil in intense fire until sparks fly out from it, or in modern terms, until it becomes **red hot**.

What it does: Completely **destroys** the absorbed flavors — they no longer exist. Essentially makes the utensil like new.

When required: When the utensil was used to cook **dry** food (without liquid).

Modern reality: Almost no utensils today can withstand becoming red hot. Therefore, anything requiring libun generally **cannot be kashered** — you put it away and buy new.

One exception: Inside an oven (self-clean function or extended high heat).

Note: Ashkenazim distinguish between libun chamur (severe) and libun kal (lighter). For Sephardim, we discuss libun as one category.

2. Hag'alah (Immersion in Boiling Water)

Definition: Immersing the utensil in a pot of boiling water.

What it does: Removes the absorbed flavors and transfers them into the boiling water. The flavors still exist (unlike libun which destroys them).

When required: When the utensil was used to cook food **with liquid**.

This is the method used for the vast majority of kitchen utensils.

Why Doesn't the Flavor Get Re-Absorbed?

Two explanations given:

1. The boiling water is assumed to be 60 times the volume of the expelled flavor — so the flavor is nullified.
2. Since the boiling water is causing the flavor to exit, it lacks the ability to re-absorb it into the walls.

Key Principles

Noten Ta'am Li-Fgam (Spoiled Flavor)

From the Torah's perspective, any flavor absorbed in a utensil for **24 hours or more** is considered rotten/spoiled (pagum). It would not add any benefit to food cooked in it.

Therefore, from the Torah, a clean pot unused for 24 hours may be used to cook kosher food — even if it previously cooked completely non-kosher food.

The Chachamim forbade this le-chatchila — concerned a person might use it within 24 hours.

Be-di'avad: If you accidentally cooked in a chametz pot that was clean and unused for 24+ hours, even on Pesach itself — the food is permitted.

Situation	Ruling
Le-chatchila	Do not cook in a chametz pot, even after 24 hours, without kashering
Be-di'avad (accidentally used it after 24 hours)	Food is permitted — even on Pesach (Sephardim)

Ashkenazim are stringent and say noten ta'am li-fgam does not apply on Pesach.
Sephardim hold that regular year-round rules apply, and therefore noten ta'am li-fgam is mutar even on Pesach.

Kli Rishon, Irui, and Kli Sheni

Term	Definition	Example
Kli Rishon (primary utensil)	The pot in which food was cooked on the fire	Pot on the stove
Irui Kli Rishon (pouring from primary)	The stream poured from a kli rishon	Pouring from a kettle. Can cook only "k'dei klipah" — the outer layer.
Kli Sheni (secondary utensil)	The vessel receiving the poured liquid	Bowl, cup, plate that food is poured/served into

Rov Tashmish (Majority Use) — SEPHARDIM ONLY

This is a critical principle, often unknown:

You kasher according to the **majority use** of the utensil — not its occasional use.

Scenario	Required Kashering
Pot usually used with liquid, occasionally used dry	Hag'alah (not libun) — follow the majority
Plate/cutlery usually used with cold, occasionally used with hot	Just wash — follow the majority
Cup usually used with cold drinks, once or twice used with hot	Just wash

Ashkenazim do NOT hold this. If a utensil was used even once with chametz in a manner requiring hag'alah/libun, they require the full process.

Why does this work? After 24 hours, retained flavor is only problematic mi-de-rabbanan. The Chachamim only imposed this concern for regular/majority usage — not for occasional, irregular use.

Heitera Bala vs. Issura Bala (Permissible vs. Prohibited Absorption)

Type	When the Flavor Was Absorbed	Kashering Required
Heitera bala	The food was permissible at the time of absorption (e.g., chametz during the year — permitted to eat)	Even dry use → only hag'alah needed (Rabbeinu Tam)
Issura bala	The food was prohibited at the time of absorption (e.g., non-kosher meat)	Dry use → libun required

Machloket on chametz: Is chametz absorbed during the year considered heitera bala (it was permissible when you cooked it) or issura bala (because it's forbidden on Pesach)?

Opinion	Chametz Is...	Consequence
Rabbeinu Tam	Heitera bala — permissible absorption	Even dry chametz use → hag'alah suffices
Rif / Shulchan Aruch	Issura bala — treated as prohibited absorption	Dry chametz use → libun required

The Shulchan Aruch follows the stricter view — but Rabbeinu Tam's opinion is used as a factor in lenient rulings (safek sefeika).

Practical Process of Hag'alah

Before Kashering

- The utensil should **not be used for 24 hours** before kashering (le-chatchila). If you did kasher within 24 hours — it's still acceptable be-di'avad.
- **Clean thoroughly** — scrub away all dirt and rust. If heavily rusted, don't kasher it.
- Good practice: use chemicals when cleaning (ensures noten ta'am li-fgam even if within 24 hours).

The Process

1. Take a large pot and boil water in it (this pot can be either chametz or Pesach — either is fine).
2. Place the utensil into the boiling water.
3. **Does not need to be done in one go** (unlike tevilat kelim). You can dip half, then turn it around and dip the other half.
4. Can leave utensils at the bottom — no requirement to remove immediately.

5. **Good minhag:** Wash with cold water immediately upon removal (to prevent re-absorption while still hot). Not essential — if you didn't, it's fine.

Timing

All hag'alah should be completed by the **morning of Erev Pesach** (the fifth hour of the day). If done after this time, additional complex laws apply.

Practical Guide: Utensil by Utensil

Metal Plates & Bowls (Kli Sheni)

Plates and bowls into which food is poured from a pot are kli sheni.

Kashering: Pour boiling water into/onto them (irui kli rishon).

Strictly speaking (Chacham Ovadia): Kli sheni does not absorb or expel — me'ikar ha-din all plates could be used for Pesach just by washing. However, as a chumra for Pesach, we pour boiling water on them.

Be-di'avad: If you accidentally served hot Pesach food onto metal chametz plates — the food is permitted (Sephardim only, not Ashkenazim).

Cutlery (Normally Kli Sheni)

Almost all cutlery is used as kli sheni (eating from plates, not cooking on fire).

Kashering: Pour boiling water from a kettle over all the cutlery (place in a bowl, pour over). This is sufficient.

Exception: Knives or utensils used directly on the fire (stirring pots on the stove) — these are kli rishon and need full hag'alah (dipping in boiling water).

Cutlery used only with cold food during the year: Just wash. No kashering needed. Even if used once or twice with hot — follow rov tashmish (Sephardim).

Cups Used Only for Cold Drinks

Just wash and use for Pesach. Cold cannot absorb.

Pots and Pans Used with Liquid

Hag'alah — dip in boiling water. Standard process.

Pans Greased with Minimal Oil (Just to Prevent Burning)

Machloket: Some say this counts as "dry" (needs libun → can't kasher). Others say the oil counts as liquid (hag'alah suffices).

Chacham Ovadia: Lenient — hag'alah is sufficient. Based on a safek sefeika combining the oil question with Rabbeinu Tam's heitera bala opinion.

Non-Stick Pans

The entire purpose is cooking without liquid (dry). This requires libun, which will destroy the non-stick coating.

Put them away for Pesach. Cannot be kashered.

Earthenware / Porcelain / Glazed China

Used With...	Can It Be Kashered?
Hot food during the year	❌ Cannot be kashered. Must be put away and locked/cordoned off. Cannot even use for cold on Pesach (gezeirah — might come to use with heat).
Only cold food during the year	✅ Immerse in cold water for three 24-hour periods → can then be used on Pesach even for hot food.

Chacham Ovadia rules glazed chinaware and porcelain have the same status as earthenware.

Glass

Glass does not absorb and does not expel.

Just wash and use for Pesach — even if used with hot chametz during the year. This is not a leniency — it is the din of the Shulchan Aruch.

Includes: Drinking glasses, glass bowls, glass serving dishes.

Pyrex: Chacham Ovadia holds Pyrex has the same status as glass — just wash, can be used to cook in the oven on Pesach.

Ashkenazim: Do not hold this regarding glass. However, combined with rov tashmish and the safek whether glass absorbs, there is often a sfek sfeka to rely on.

Plastics

Chacham Ovadia holds plastics can be kashered the same way as metals — following the same rules (hag'alah if used with liquid, etc.). Note: the process may damage the plastic.

Microwave

Chacham Ovadia: Be machmir — treat it as if it absorbs.

Process:

1. Clean thoroughly
2. Wait 24 hours
3. Place a bowl of water inside
4. Run on highest setting for a few minutes until steam fills the interior
5. Good to go

Dishwasher

Sephardim: Can be used for Pesach.

Process:

1. Clean all trays and grooves thoroughly — ensure no chametz remains
2. Run a full cycle on the highest setting with detergent
3. Good to go — no separate Pesach dishwasher needed

Rationale: The chemicals and heat during regular cycles make all absorbed flavors completely mutar. (Chacham Ovadia holds the same principle year-round — a dishwasher can even be used for meat and milk separately.)

Oven

Process:

1. Clean thoroughly (use oven cleaner/chemicals)
2. If it has **self-clean** → run the self-clean cycle. Done.
3. If no self-clean → clean well, then run on high for about an hour. Good to go.

Oven racks: Self-clean may damage them. If you don't want to risk it → buy new racks. Racks cannot be kashered with hag'alah (they're used dry/with direct heat).

Stovetop / Hob (Gas Burners)

Process:

1. Clean thoroughly — burners and all parts
2. Turn on all burners on high for approximately one hour
3. Good to go

Glass Induction Hob

It's glass. Just wash it. Glass doesn't absorb.

Sinks

Pour boiling water directly onto every part of the sink.

Critical: Do not pour onto one spot and let it trickle — each part must receive direct irui (pouring). Go in circles around the basin, then up the walls.

Chacham Ovadia notes this is itself a chumra — it's unlikely the sink ever absorbed at yad soledet bo temperature. But we do it.

Alternative: If you prefer, just cover the sink. But kashering properly means no covering is needed.

Countertops

If used with hot items during the year: Pour boiling water directly over every part (same as sinks — don't just pour in one spot and let it trickle).

If only used with cold items: Just clean. No kashering needed.

If you always use trivets for hot pots: Arguably the countertop was only used cold — just cleaning may suffice (based on rov tashmish).

Alternative: Cover with foil instead of kashering.

You do NOT need to do both. Either kasher OR cover. Both is unnecessary.

Hot Plate (Plata / Shabbat Plate)

Process:

1. Clean thoroughly (use chemicals)
2. Wait 24 hours
3. Turn on high for about an hour
4. Good to go — no foil covering needed if kashered properly

Fire safety note: Israeli fire services have warned against covering hot plates with foil — heat reflects downward and can reach dangerous temperatures (200°C+). If you must keep food warm, place pans in disposable foil containers on the hot plate instead.

Urn / Water Heater

If only used for boiling water (tea, coffee): Clean and use for Pesach. No chametz contact.

If the lid was used to warm challot etc.: Kasher the lid with hag'alah (dip in boiling water). The body of the urn is fine.

Soda Machine

All cold. Just clean and use.

Barbecue Spit / Grill Grates

Used dry with direct fire → requires libun (red hot). Cannot practically be done today.

Cannot be kashered for Pesach. Buy new or put away.

Kiddush Cup (Silver)

If only used for cold grape juice/wine during the year → just wash. No kashering needed (both Sephardim and Ashkenazim agree).

Summary Table

Utensil	Method	Notes
Metal pots (used with liquid)	Hag'alah	Wait 24 hours, dip in boiling water
Metal plates/bowls	Irui (pour boiling water)	Kli sheni — be-di'avad just washing is fine
Cutlery (eating)	Irui (pour boiling water)	Almost always kli sheni
Cutlery (used on fire)	Hag'alah	Kli rishon — dip in boiling water
Pans with minimal oil	Hag'alah	Chacham Ovadia lenient — safek sefeika
Non-stick pans	Cannot kasher	Needs libun → put away
Earthenware / china (hot use)	Cannot kasher	Lock away for Pesach
Earthenware (cold use only)	3 × 24 hours cold water	Then usable even for hot on Pesach
Glass / Pyrex	Just wash	Does not absorb (Sephardim)
Plastic	Same as metal	May damage the plastic
Microwave	Steam with water on high	Clean, wait 24 hours, bowl of water, few minutes
Dishwasher	Clean + run hot cycle	No separate Pesach dishwasher needed
Oven	Self-clean or high heat ~1 hour	Racks may need replacing
Stovetop / hob	High heat ~1 hour	Clean burners first
Glass induction hob	Just wash	Glass doesn't absorb
Sink	Direct irui everywhere	Don't let water trickle — pour directly
Countertops	Direct irui or cover	Either kasher OR cover, not both
Hot plate	Clean + high heat ~1 hour	No foil needed if kashered
Urn	Clean (kasher lid if used with challah)	Body fine if only used for water
Soda machine	Just clean	All cold
BBQ spit/grill	Cannot kasher	Needs libun → put away

Kiddush cup (cold use)	Just wash	No kashering needed

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